ICE AGE GIVES WAY TO EV ERA



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2025 will be the turning point for India's auto industry, as electric vehicles surge mainstream with fierce competition among top players



Maruti Suzuki eVitara



MG Windsor



Hyundai CRETA Electric

2025 will probably be that watershed year which historians will bookmark as the dawn of the EV era in this country. And no, it will not be because Tesla will finally make it to India nor will it be because the Chinese car makers will overrun the Indian car industry like they are poised to do the world over with their EVs. It will be because the top 5 car makers in the country, representing nearly 90 per cent of the passenger car industry, will all have attractive EVs on sale. And some of them putting their very first EV on the market. The companies sixth and seventh on the list already have EVs in their portfolio that they will be further expanding. Leaving Honda and Jeep aside, the rest of the companies also already have, or will have, EVs on the market in 2025, as will newcomers like VinFast.

The big news is of course Maruti Suzuki's entry into the EV space in 2025, albeit with a top-down approach, much like that of Hyundai. Both will enter the market with electric versions of their best-selling mid-sized SUVs, the Creta Electric and the eVitara, making their long-standing rivalry electric. Mahindra has already showcased the BE 6 and the XE 7e while Tata Motors is slowly working its way up from the likes of the electric versions of the Tiago, Tigor and Nexon to the Punch and the Curvv.

If Maruti Suzuki has an EV, so will Toyota and if Hyundai is making an EV in India, so will Kia and we are also likely to see the electric avatar of the Carens this year. MG already has a portfolio that includes three EVs, including the Windsor which has been India's best-selling EV for the last few months and is changing the game in people's perception of EVs as expensive and/or small vehicles. It costs as much as a small vehicle, it will run for nearly free for the first year and then for a fraction of the running cost of an ICE vehicle, and it looks and feels like, and has the space of a large car. BYD already has a portfolio of three EVs in the country and who does that leave us with? Volkswagen and Skoda will also be launching EVs this year while Renault and Nissan as well as Honda seem to be the inconsequential three, leaving question marks about their future in the country.

What will change the game for EVs in the country, I have long maintained, is the entry of the market leader into this segment. But what I could not have foreseen was that Maruti Suzuki's entry would coincide with 90 per cent of the industry selling EVs, competing with each other and coming out with more innovative ideas to attract the car-buying public to EVs. The future is here. ■